sent by Akbar in the Haram Sharif. It would appear that Gulbadan and her Mughal party's largesse, which challenged the Ottoman authorities' prestige, in addition to the hustling crowds attracted by them, made Sultan Murad III keen to be rid of the Hindustani pilgrims. The royal ladies would finally depart from Mecca in 1580, much against their wishes, and return to Hindustan, bringing back mementos and curiosities, Arab servants, and a lifetime of memories of ecstatic passions and cacophonous celebrations.

At Fatehpur Sikri, meanwhile, the women of the harem continued their involvement with more domestic duties in increasingly guarded spaces. 'Several chaste women have been appointed as darogahs and superintendents over each section,' noted Abu'l Fazl primly, about the women in the harem, who were moreover guarded by 'sober and active women, the most trustworthy of them placed about the apartments of his Majesty'. While the inside of the palaces were guarded by strong women called the urdubegis,* the outside was guarded by eunuchs; the next outer perimeter was guarded by Rajputs, and then there were the porters at the gates and, on all four sides, squads of Ahadis. The women were assigned salaries, 'sufficiently liberal, not counting the presents, which his Majesty most generously bestows'. The salaries ranged from Rs 1,610 per month to the most senior women to Rs 20 to the servants.

The Rajput women, too, when they married and left their homes, were given jagirs called hath kharach jagir (personal expenses land) which they administered directly through their own officers, thus maintaining some financial independence, vital in a polygamous society. An important wedding organized at this time was the marriage of Abdur Rahim, eighteen years old now, to a daughter of Jiji Anaga, Mah Banu Begum. This was an important alliance for the young nobleman, and it brought him the considerable influence of the Ataka Khail, and also made him the brother-in-law of the temperamental but talented and powerful Mirza Aziz Koka. Akbar now gave Abdur Rahim the title 'khan', usually only reserved for princes of the blood, and henceforth always addressed him as 'Mirza Khan'.

It was at this time that Aziz Koka, in his long and tumultuous career, temporarily fell from favour. Akbar's orders regarding the branding of animals was resented by the old Central Asian nobility, who saw in this system of inspection a further curbing of their power. Aziz, it was felt, had grumbled rather too openly at the branding order. 'Everything that he knew about these things,' wrote Badauni about Aziz's criticism of branding, 'he